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### A FORMER CORPORATION COMMISSIONER'S NAME LIVES ON, IN DIFFERENT FORMS

Nearly 10 years since historian V. Sriram pointed out two nameboards that massacred Sir Eric Conran-Smith's name, the twin errors persist. **P3**



### HAVE YOU INVITED A MADRAS MALI TO YOUR GARDEN?

On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme **P4**

## A parody of a park at Koluthuvanchery

Equipment at the children's play area are damaged; unruly vegetation around the park provides a conducive environment for reptiles



B. SANTHOSH

For want of regular maintenance, the Nadunkulam pond on Bharaniputhur Road in Koluthuvanchery, which comes under Iyppanthangal Village Panchayat, wears a pathetic look.

The waterbody was restored and a park was developed around it a few years ago; and residents be-

gan to make a beeline to the leisure facility.

But due to poor maintenance, the facility has become uninviting and the number of visitors has dwindled considerably.

The equipment at the children's play area are damaged. The play area is covered with a carpet of dry leaf litter. A spread of ash can be found in various parts of the park, suggesting burning of waste regu-

larly. There is no compound wall and therefore youngsters drive inside the premises of the park. The place is also misused for alcohol consumption at night.

Unruly vegetation around the park provides a conducive environment for venomous reptiles.

It may be noted the contractor who is carrying out stormwater drain construction in the vicinity is making use of the park as a store-



The park on Bharaniputhur Road in Koluthuvanchery.



house for construction material and as a place of accommodation for his workers. I see this as an encroachment of public space and Iyppanthangal Village Panchayat should take stringent measures against this.

Further, the pond is overrun with all kinds of waste, including plastic, food packets and clothes.

Further, the RO water plant and a community room is under lock and key.

It is unsafe to use the park after dusk as it is poorly lit.

I request Iyppanthangal Village Panchayat to restore the waterbody and the park.

**B. Santhosh** is a resident of Iyppanthangal

## Work on Alandur pedestrian pathway begins

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

On March 2, bhoomi pooja was conducted for the work aimed at elevating Alandur pedestrian pathway to a two- and three-wheeler-cum-pedestrian subway.

MLA T. M. Anbarasan laid the foundation stone.

This has been a long-standing plea of motorists. They had made this plea known to the State Highways Department as this infrastructural upgrade would prevent them from going the extra mile to take a U-turn.

At present, motorists from St. Thomas Mount Railway Station Road and Subway Lane Road have to navigate GST Road and take a



The U turn at St Thomas Mount; and (right) Alandur subway. PHOTOS: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

U-turn along St. Thomas Garrison Church.

A. Rajesh, a motorist, said, "The traffic flow along the subway is never-ending as motorists come from Guindy, Alandur and descend from Ekkattuthangal and Vadapalani. The lane is also wide."

Motorists from Railway Station Road and the Sub-

way Lane Road must drive carefully to reach along the medians as there are no speed breakers, says V. Rama Rao, director, Traffic and Transportation Forum.

The other option is to drive left and approach the medians along St. Thomas Mount post office, where traffic slows due to U-turn signals. The other option is



to stop at the signal on the left, then take the U-turn.

If the underpass is made a vehicular subway, it will reduce the time to reach the lane towards Kathipara Grade Separator against the present U-turn, alleviate risk and save fuel.

The project is expected to be completed in six months at a cost of ₹8.13 crores.

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The E Seva Aadhar Centre at the office of Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



## Additional E Seva Aadhar Centre opened in Iyyappanthangal

R.K. RAVICHANDRAN

An additional E Seva Aadhar Centre was inaugurated at Iyyappanthangal last week. It is located inside the office of Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat. This one is directly operated by the Electronics Corporation of Tamil Nadu Limited (ELCOT) while the existing ones are operated by private entities holding a license. Due to increase in population in the area, the need for an additional E Seva Aadhar Centre was badly felt. If someone is keen

on using the services of an ELCOT-operated centre, they had to go to Porur, Mangadu or Poonamallee, which was inconvenient.

Therefore, Iyyappanthangal Bharaniputhur Consumer Rights Protection Society made a representation to ELCOT a couple of years ago and the society has been pursuing the matter since then. We thank ELCOT for honouring our request.

**R.K. Ravichandran** is the founder and president of IyyappanthangalBharaniputhur Consumer Rights Protection Society

## 'Disruption in power supply at staircase is frequent'



V JOHAN DHANAKUMAR

Power supply gets disrupted often at the staircase of the foot overbridge at platform one at Mambalam railway station. Last week I happened to notice many commuters, especially se-

nior citizens and women, stumbling due to a power cut.

Though a power cut usually lasts a few minutes, this is clearly a serious safety issue and I request Southern Railway to address it.

**V Johan Dhanakumar** is a resident of Choolaimedu

## You can be our volunteer writer

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## 'Garbage woes in Karambakkam'

S. PALANIAPPAN

The image shows overflowing waste bins at the intersection of Dharmaraja Koil Main Road and Mothy Nagar Main Road at Karambakkam in Porur. Here, loads of waste generated from eateries also are dumped here. Most of the time, it is overflowing and the place stinks. It may be noted this junction witnesses good traffic as it leads to Vanagaram toll-gate.

**S. Palaniappan** is a resident of Karambakkam



The Marina beach has a culture of sculpted art; by its design and focus, this one is hugely different from the other works adorning the leisure spot

M. SRINATH

The Marina beach is known for its works of sculpture, sporting an impressive array of them in spaces that passersby cannot miss even with their eyes closed. There is now an addition to this culture of sculpted art at the beach, and this one is massively different, not just in its de-

## A new selfie point at the Marina?



PHOTO: SRINATH M

sign but also in its focus. It is a commentary on what education can do for individuals and com-

munities and nations.

In a design that spirals into the sky, books are displayed,

and they are kept open, as if they had been plucked out of reading sessions.

The books being placed on a twisting column lends the artwork a sense of motion, when viewed from a physical lens, and one of mobility, when seen from the perspective of societal development.

Under the picture of erudition are huge-sized sculpted figures of people from various stations and age groups, underlining the universality of education. The group of people also seem to signify collective effort; and literacy from the perspective of a community, city, state and nation.

As is to be expected, this work executed by Greater Chennai Corporation has the partnership of the Education Department.

There are selfie points at the Marina; and this one can be an massive addition to them, its off-beat design being a big draw.



# A former Corporation Commissioner's name lives on, in different forms



Nearly 10 years since historian V. Sriram pointed out that two road name boards would cause Sir Eric Conran-Smith to turn in his grave, those twin errors persist



## PRINCE FREDERICK

There is honest error. And there is something called persisting in an honest error either out of ignorance or maverick indifference. One assumes, and fervently hopes, ignorance is the reason Sir Eric Conran-Smith is assuming a *nom de guerre* at the drop of a quintessentially British bowler hat.

On a Greater Chennai Corporation name board for a famous road in Gopalapuram, he goes under “Conron Smith”. If disguise is the objective, that is a weak attempt at it. A few paces into this road and a turn later, he gets better at the game, morphing into Kandran Smith, a name board for a lane off Conran Smith Road hilariously carrying ‘Kandran Smith Lane’.

The images of these two name boards were clicked as recently as February 27, 2026 (and at the time of this article going to press on March 7, 2026 these name boards continued un-



Two name boards that maul Sir Eric Conran-Smith's name; and the statue at Ripon buildings that does justice to his memory and more importantly, his name. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK AND R. RAGU

fingers were jabbing at the keyboard, Sir Eric Conran-Smith served as Commissioner of the Corporation of Madras; the city had been this Briton's stomping ground. Sriram twists the knife by adding that the sta-

tue of this worthy adorns a prominent section of Ripon Buildings, GCC's headquarters, which does justice to his memory and more thankfully, to his name. Those snippets of information upgrades Sir Eric Conran-Smith to Worthy Plus, and the shoddy name board job from an error to a grave error.

Here we are, in 2026, in the unfortunate position of having to point out those twin errors yet again.

While British worthies are losing name boards to Indian heroes in a road-renaming frenzy, their wigs twirling in disappointment, Sir Eric

Conran-Smith must be hoping and praying diligently from his well-appointed Elysian apartment that he lose these name boards in a city whose care was once entrusted with him.

changed). And nearly ten years before this “photo shoot”, in the column Hidden Histories in *The Hindu* (September 23, 2016), historian V. Sriram had drawn attention to how a worthy's name is being taken in vain, twice and within the distance of a few hundred metres. And this worthy is not just any worthy. In the column, Sriram points out, surely his tongue wedged in cheek while his surprised

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# Have you invited a **Madras Mali** to your garden?

They grow gardens in other people's backyards but the blooms extend into their living rooms. On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme designed by Chennai Resilience Centre



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

**M**any had spent years as homemakers with little opportunity for paid work. Today, as part of the Madras Malis initiative, they travel across neighbourhoods helping households establish and maintain organic kitchen gardens.

The programme traces its roots to the Chennai Resilience Centre's Chennai Urban Farming Initiative, launched in 2021 to promote organic edible gardening in urban spaces. The idea was simple: encourage residents to grow food at home, both as a source of nutrition and as a way to create greener, climate-resilient neighbourhoods where plants help reduce urban heat. Workshops and training sessions were organised with residents, teachers and community groups across the city. But as participation grew, organisers began noticing a recurring challenge. While many residents were eager to start kitchen gardens, sustaining them required technical knowledge most did not possess.

"Residents often told us that even after attending workshops, maintaining a garden was still difficult," says Ayesha Ajmal, Junior Re-

search Associate and Communications Manager at the Chennai Resilience Centre, who coordinates Mali assignments, manages social media, and assists with training sessions. "There were challenges with pests, soil health and identifying the right inputs to use."

Organisers also recognised another gap. While gardeners were available in the city, most focused on routine tasks such as watering or pruning. Few had the expertise to maintain edible gardens using organic techniques or diagnose plant health problems.

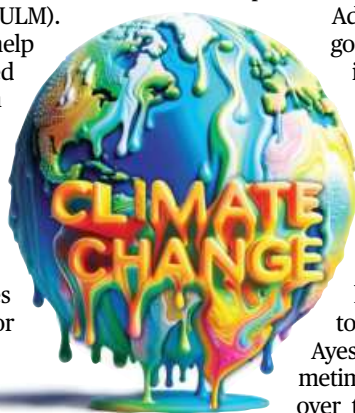
To address this, while also creating livelihood opportunities, the initiative began collaborating with the Tamil Nadu Urban Livelihoods Mission (TNULM). Women from self-help groups were invited to participate in specialised gardening training. This effort gradually evolved into the Madras Mali programme. Ayesha underlines that eligibility for participating in the training

programme is predicated on a woman's membership in a self-help group registered under TNULM.

Between 2022 and 2024, the initiative operated as a pilot under the Urban Thottam project, experimenting with training formats while connecting trained women with households seeking help. By 2025, the programme was formally structured and launched under the name Madras Mali, with a dedicated website, social media presence and a defined list of services. Since 2023, nearly 250 women have received training. The training is designed in stages. Participants begin with fundamentals – soil preparation, plant varieties and common pests.

Advanced sessions go deeper into pruning, identifying fungal infections and diagnosing nutrient deficiencies. "These sessions are usually conducted in modules lasting around two to three hours,"

Ayesha explains. "Sometimes they take place over two or three days



M. Krishnaveni (wearing a hat) from Chintadripet talks to a client about a plant; V. Prabha from R.A. Puram and B. Geetha from Taramani, also at work in their respective client's garden. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their confidence. B. Geetha from Taramani says the work has given her a sense of financial independence. "Earlier, I depended on my husband even for small things. If my children asked for a pencil or a book, I had to ask him for money. Now I can manage these small expenses myself." Appreciation from residents keeps her motivated too. "Residents sometimes send photos of the harvest. Seeing that makes me feel very satisfied." Others say the programme has expanded their world beyond their immediate neighbourhoods.

V. Prabha from R.A. Puram, who has been working as a Mali for three years, says the experience has made her more confident. "Earlier I hardly stepped outside my area. Now I know some bus routes and I can interact with more people." Gardening has also become a passion. "I keep encouraging people around me to grow more plants at home."

Their work has extended beyond private homes to schools and community institutions, including a Greater Chennai Corporation High School at Kamaraj Avenue in Adyar, the Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust in Teynampet, Little Flower Nursery and Primary School in Adambakkam and Government Higher Secondary School in Sholinganallur. Students are often involved in sowing and harvesting, turning gardens into learning spaces, with vegetables sometimes used in the institutions' kitchens. "Seeing them eat the greens they harvest for lunch feels more fulfilling than the money," says one of the Madras Malis, M. Krishnaveni from Chintadripet.

## The challenges

Like many livelihood initiatives, the programme comes with challenges. Working through Chennai's summers can be gruelling, and the work occasionally involves physically demanding tasks such as carrying heavy pots. Managing client expectations has also required attention; organisers now address this by clearly explaining the scope of work to both parties before assignments begin.

Despite these challenges, the initiative continues to grow largely through word of mouth. Many clients who first hear about the service through friends or neighbours eventually become repeat users. Those interested in availing the Madras Mali service can contact the team via WhatsApp at 9176588007. More details are available at urbanthottam.com/madras-mali-veg-garden-kit/ and @urbanthottam on Instagram.



depending on the women's availability."

Beyond classroom sessions, participants are also exposed to organic farming at scale. In late 2023, a group attended a residential programme at a farm run by the Centre for Indian Knowledge Systems near Vedanthangal, where they explored traditional vegetable varieties, visited rice fields and participated in organic farming demonstrations.

The programme also emphasises entrepreneurial skills. Participants learn to prepare organic pesticides and plant growth promoters using locally available ingredients, which they can market to clients. They are also trained to set up composting systems and guide households in converting kitchen waste into compost. For the Malis, minimum payment is fixed at ₹850 for five hours; the Malis receive the payment directly from the clients and Chennai Resilience Centre does not receive a commission.

## A confidence boost

For many participants, the most visible transformation has been in



# Camp for *women artists*

Three city-based artists are coordinating this event, taking place at the Gallery of Contemporary Art in Egmore Museum today



▼ The organisers of the event.  
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

being from Chennai. On March 7, there will be a live painting session and on March 8, the completed art-works will be exhibited at the gallery in celebration of International Women's Day.

The idea behind this camp was put forward by three Chennai-based artists Sathya N. Prabhu, Charanya Rajesh and Gayathri Balaji. "We initially planned to celebrate International Women's Day with a spot painting event and exhibition. When we approached the museum, we were surprised by the enthusiastic support extended by the Department of Museums" says Charanya. The event will see budding and aspiring artists, some juggling full-time jobs, working on different mediums and networking with each other.

This initiative aims to provide a meaningful platform for showcasing the talent of women artists and promoting art and creativity.

The event encourages women, especially homemakers, to come and see the works and interact with artists to see how this can be taken up as a profession.

**T**he Department of Museums is organising an artists camp for women on March 7 and 8 at the Gallery of Contemporary Art

in Egmore.

More than 70 women artists from across Tamil Nadu will be participating in this special event, a majority

# Celebrating their strength, resilience



▼ During the event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The ninth edition of Realistic Awards was held recently in the city. A social initiative by Pakwan Chennai, SPICA Modular Solutions Limited, Realistic Awards honours women who lead, inspire and redefine excellence in their respective fields.

This year, 20 women from diverse fields were recognised for their passion, perseverance and groundbreaking contributions.

They are Rachitha Mahalakshmi (small screen), Shrinidhi, a radio jockey, Anitha Guha, classical dancer, Lavanya, classical singer, Rakshita Suresh, playback singer, Vagu Mazan, independent artist, Akshatha Das, video jockey, G Kavya, choreographer, Meenu

Balaji, a nutritionist and dietitian, Dr Vasundra Thiagarajan, doctor, Salomi Rinita, a make-up artist, Padmini Ravichandran, journalist, Krithika Subrahmanian, architect, Thanupa Santosh (Human Resources), Urvashi Deshpande, interior designer, Preetha Raghav (global facilitator and leadership catalyst), Suramanjari Elangovan, entrepreneur (Fintech), Malar Vikram, costume designer, and Darsani for sports.

On the occasion, the lifetime achievement award was given to veteran actress Rajyalakshmi, honouring her lasting legacy and decades of contributions to Indian cinema and television, the release added.

## Three-day training programme on **Generative AI**

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conduct a training programme on Generative AI from March 11 to 13 at its campus in Guindy.

According to a press release, programme is designed to help entrepreneurs understand and apply Generative AI in their business operations without requiring technical or programming knowledge. However, basic knowledge to use a computer and a

smartphone is necessary.

### Session on E - commerce

The institute is also conducting a workshop on E - Commerce from March 16 to 18.

Participants will learn about setting up an online store. They will be introduced to types of e commerce models, designing a store, product management and inventory, setting up payment gateways, social media marketing, pay-per-click advertising, logistics management (shipping and delivery), and financial management in e-commerce. Basic computer knowledge is required, adds the press release

### Workshop on drone operations

Another programme on media drone operations will be held from March 10 to 12. According to a press release, participants will learn about drone technology, drone cinematography, and FPV Cinematography.

The session will also focus on rules, regulations and safety guidelines prescribed by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation. This skill will help the participants find opportunities in sectors such as media, marketing and advertisement, rescue operations, and surveillance, adds the release. For details, call 9360221280 / 9840114680 / 8668100181.

## Workshop on **Tanjore paintings**



Artist Kanimozhi is conducting a workshop on Tanjore paintings and other traditional Indian art forms, including Madhubani, Warli, Gond, Patachitra, Nirmal, Zulu, Kerala Mural, and Rajasthani paintings.

The workshop is open to ladies and children and will be conducted at SAF Games Village, Koyambedu from March 8 to 23. For details, contact Kanimozhi at 9381157831

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